



FIRST IMPRESSIONS

The first draft of the opera Billy Budd is played to writer Ronald Duncan (center) and musician Arthur Oldham. At the piano, Britten accompanies Peter Pears singing one of the arias.

“ My **subject** is **War**, and the **pity** of **War**.
”

WILFRED OWEN, QUOTED ON THE TITLE PAGE OF
BRITTEN’S WAR REQUIEM, 1962

War and pacifism

The last years of the 1930s were dominated by the approach of World War II. Britten was an adherent of the pacifist Peace Pledge Union. In early 1939, he traveled with Pears to North